

FACELIFT AWAITED The dilapidated 'Pather Puri', once associated with Tagore

the youth, to engage with the lives and contributions of these personalities through museums, interpretation centres, cultural programmes and local economic activities."

The list of sites reflects Odisha's attempt to weave together multiple historical strands. To begin with, the native places of the 'Panchasakhas'. These are the five 16th-century poet-saints of Odisha, all contemporaries of Bhakti-era luminary Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, who are seen as progenitors of the golden age of Odia literature: Balaram Das, Atibadi Jagannath Das, Mahapurusha Achyutananda Das, Jasobanta Das and Sishu Ananta Das. Then comes a diverse pantheon: literary giant Fakir Mohan Senapati, the first chief minister Dr Harekrushna Mahtab, playwright Nityananda Mahapatra, tribal leader Dharanidhar Bhuyan, Ol Chiki script creator Dr Raghunath Murmu, freedom fighter Laxmi Indira Panda and the legendary child martyr, Baji Rout.

Personalities associated with Odisha's resistance traditions, including the Paika Rebellion, the state's unification movement and India's freedom struggle are a special part of the list. Each site will feature open-air theatres and dedicated spaces for showcasing and selling local products, so as to create a live ambience, besides interpretation centres and museums that will attempt to lure in the crowds for a deeper dive. District collectors and the state archaeology department have been tasked with identifying land and initiating the tendering process.

Takeaways

- **Native villages of the Panchasakhas—16th c. poet-saints—to turn into 'living heritage spaces'**
- **A diverse modern Odia pantheon too on the list, as is Tagore's Pather Puri**
- **Warrior queen central to Kalinga memorial plan**

A TAGOREAN DETOUR

In a parallel project, the state has approved Rs 12 crore for the restoration of Pather Puri, the historic seaside residence in Puri associated with Rabindranath Tagore. The project has been entrusted to the Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH). Tagore frequently stayed at the property during his visits to Odisha. During his final visit in April-May 1939, he wrote at least three poems—*Pravasi*, *Janmadin* and *Epare Opare*. He had visited Odisha as a state guest of Bishwanath Das, then prime minister of what was called Orissa province. Before leaving, Tagore expressed his desire to donate the property to the government. The building later served as a hostel for students of Puri's Samanta Chandra Sekhar College before gradually falling into disrepair.

"The building will be restored completely to what it once was," says Anil Kumar Dhir of INTACH. "We want visitors to experience the atmosphere that Tagore himself encountered during his stay in Puri. It will become a major cultural and tourist attraction. We are exploring ways to source and display artefacts connected to the poet, and the museum will include interactive exhibits and activities that allow visitors to engage with his life and work in meaningful ways."

Another project under consideration seeks to connect Odisha's ancient history with its contemporary identity. The government is planning to construct the Tarpan Sheela Stambh near Dhauli, overlooking the historic battlefield of the Kalinga war. The proposal originated from noted Odia author and academic Dr Pratibha Ray. Officials say the proposed pillar would be large enough to be visible from the Bhubaneswar-Puri national highway, much like the existing Peace Pagoda built with Japanese support. While emperor Ashoka is central to the narrative, the memorial is also expected to highlight Karuvaki, the Kalinga woman believed to have resisted Ashoka before later becoming his fourth wife. Two locations have been shortlisted.

The state has also enlisted IIT Kharagpur and the School of Planning and Architecture to provide technical expertise for preserving nearly 3,000 identified artefacts scattered across Odisha. Some officials in the culture department admit to the difficulty in finding organisations with the expertise needed to implement a project like Baraputra Aitihya Gram Yojana. Yet, with the BJP's cultural identity plank behind the endeavour, forward movement is likelier than not. ■